Getting your Slack app ready for real users

Everything between "I need my own Slack OAuth app" and "any customer can connect": which app type to pick, which scopes cost you what, the limits before review, and the parts only you can do.

Tested on Oct 28, 2026 | Checked against Slack docs | 1 open conflict

Verdict. You can have a Slack app installable in any workspace in under 10 minutes, with no review. But if your agent reads channel or thread history, that is throttled to 1 request a minute until Slack approves a Marketplace listing, and that takes up to about 12 weeks after you reach 10 active workspaces.

EASE OF CREATION

Easy

About 5 minutes from a manifest. Measured in our test.

EASE OF APPROVAL

Hard

Marketplace review, gated by 10 active workspaces.

YOUR HANDS-ON TIME

10 min to 2 days

10 minutes to a working app. 1 to 2 days to prepare a Marketplace submission.

WAITING ON SLACK

None, or ~12 weeks

None to go live. Up to 10 business days plus up to 10 weeks for Marketplace review.

DO YOU NEED YOUR OWN APP YET?

Not to start. Composio has a managed Slack app.

Move to your own app when you need your brand on the consent screen, scopes beyond Composio's defaults, or your own rate limits instead of a shared quota.

How to read this

Sections follow the order you will hit things. Red cards are decisions you cannot easily undo.

Who does what

AGENT an agent can do it | YOU needs you | WAITING on Slack

Evidence

Each key claim is tagged: tested, official docs, secondary source, conflict, or not checked. See section 13.

02 Decisions you can't undo

Read this before you click anything

Every one of these was found while creating a real app. Each is cheap to get right on day one and painful to fix later.

1 **The workspace that owns the app is permanent.**

The creation form warns it cannot be changed later, and if you leave that workspace you lose access to the app.

Do this: create the app in a workspace your company owns and will keep, never in a personal or trial workspace.

2 **Turning distribution off later uninstalls you everywhere.**

Deactivating public distribution removes the app from every workspace that installed it, and turning it back on means every customer must reinstall.

Do this: treat "Activate Public Distribution" as a one-way door once customers are on it.

3 **A Marketplace listing locks the app.**

After approval, any new scope or feature needs a resubmission with a demo video and a staging app, with up to 6 weeks of review.

Do this: request every scope you will need in the next 6 to 12 months before you submit, and keep a separate staging app.

4 **Token rotation changes how you must store tokens.**

It is off by default. Once on, tokens expire every 12 hours and each refresh revokes the previous refresh token.

Do this: decide before launch. If you turn it on, store the newest refresh token every time, or connections die with `invalid_grant`.

03 App types

Which one is right for an agent product?

Single-workspace

The default after you create an app.

WHO CAN INSTALL
Only the workspace it was built in

REVIEW
None

USE IT FOR
Building and testing

Distributed (unlisted)

After "Activate Public Distribution".

WHO CAN INSTALL
Any workspace, through your install link

REVIEW
None. Took effect instantly in our test.

USE IT FOR
Beta and first customers

Marketplace (listed)

After Slack approves your submission.

WHO CAN INSTALL
Anyone, and discoverable in Slack

REVIEW
Yes, up to about 12 weeks

USE IT FOR
Commercial product at scale

"Stay unlisted forever" is not a real option for a paid product.

Slack's API terms say an app that is monetized, or connects to a paid product, needs Slack's authorization to be distributed commercially. For most apps that means the Marketplace; a partner agreement is the alternative. Apps built for one specific customer are exempt. Official terms

Recommended path for an agent: build single-workspace, activate distribution for beta, and plan the Marketplace from day one if your agent reads messages. Slack's console now also offers an "AI agent" app template and an Agents settings page.

04 Scopes

What each permission costs you

Agents usually use **bot scopes** (the app acts as itself, token starts `xoxb-`). **User scopes** act as the person (`xoxp-`) and are needed for things like search.

AGENT USE CASE	TYPICAL BOT SCOPES	BEFORE MARKETPLACE APPROVAL
Post messages	`chat:write`	NO LIMIT
List channels and people	`channels:read` `users:read`	NO LIMIT
Read user emails	`users:read.email`	NO LIMIT
Read public channel history	`channels:history`	1 REQ/MIN, 15 MSGS
Read private channels, DMs	`groups:history` `im:history`	1 REQ/MIN, 15 MSGS
Read threads	History scopes via `conversations.replies`	1 REQ/MIN, 15 MSGS

Minimal set: "post updates" agent

`chat:write` `channels:read`

No review pressure at all.

Minimal set: "summarize my channels" agent

Adds `channels:history`, which hits the throttle immediately. See section 8.

Changing scopes later

- **While unlisted:** add scopes freely in the manifest, but every existing workspace must reinstall to grant them. Existing connections do not upgrade on their own.
- **Once listed:** a new scope needs resubmission with a demo video and a staging app. Official docs
- **In Composio:** the scopes your auth config requests must match what the app allows, then users reconnect.

05 Prerequisites

What to have ready

To create and distribute

- A company-owned Slack workspace to own the app
- A second workspace to test installs as a customer would

For the Marketplace (takes days to weeks)

- **10 or more active workspaces** (used in the last 28 days). The counter updates every 24 hours
- Public homepage, privacy policy, support contact
- Demo video: install, OAuth, setup, real use, uninstall

- An **HTTPS** redirect URL. For Composio, the callback shown in your auth config
- No hard-coded tokens or webhook URLs in your code (you attest to this)
- Test credentials and dummy data for your own product

06 Creation steps

Measured on a real app, Oct 28, 2026

1	YOU	**Sign in at api.slack.com/apps** The agent cannot sign in for you. Use the company-owned workspace (decision 1).	1 min
2	AGENT	**Create New App, choose "From a manifest"** The dialog also offers AI agent, Starter app and Blank app templates. A manifest is faster and reviewable.	1 min
3	AGENT	**Write the manifest** App name, bot user, scopes from section 4, the HTTPS redirect URL, and `token_rotation_enabled` set deliberately.	2 min
4	YOU	**Approve "Create and Install"** Creating and installing into your workspace is now a single step. Settings open at app.slack.com/app-settings.	10 sec
5	YOU	**Copy Client ID and Client Secret into Composio** Create a custom auth config and pass its ID for the slack toolkit. See section 11 on keeping the secret out of sight.	2 min
6	AGENT	**Clear the distribution checklist** With a manifest, 3 of 4 items pass automatically. The last is a checkbox confirming no hard-coded tokens.	1 min
7	YOU	**Approve "Activate Public Distribution"** No review. Took effect instantly. Without it, other workspaces get `invalid_team_for_non_distributed_app`.	5 sec
8	YOU	**Test install from a second workspace** Use an incognito window, as a new customer would.	10 min

Total in our test: about 5 minutes of agent work, one sign-in and two approvals.

07 Approval and distribution

Slack Marketplace review

When you need it: to lift the history throttle, and for commercial distribution under Slack's terms. **Cost:** none from Slack. **Renewal:** none, but listed apps are locked (decision 3).

GATE	STEP 1	STEP 2	STEP 3
10 workspaces	**Automated checks**	**≤ 10 business days**	**≤ 10 weeks**
Active in the last 28 days, before you can submit.	Run in the console before submitting.	Preliminary review of listing and scopes. Resubmitting resets your place in the queue.	Functional review: a reviewer installs and tests. Queue place is kept.

What you submit

- Listing content and scope justifications
- Security and compliance answers
- Testing information and credentials
- Demo video (install to uninstall)

Slack will not speed up review for a launch date. Submit early.

Common rejection reasons

- Broad or legacy scopes
- Scopes for features that do not exist yet
- Reviewer cannot install the app
- Coded workflows (not eligible)

08 Limits before approval

What breaks a launch after a demo that worked

BUILD AND TEST

Works in your own workspace only.

Limit: other workspaces cannot install until distribution is active.

FIRST CUSTOMERS

Any workspace can install, no review.

Limit: history and thread reads: 1 request/min, 15 messages per call.

SCALE

Marketplace listing approved.

Limit: standard rate-limit tiers. Changes need re-review.

METHOD	UNLISTED DISTRIBUTED APP	INTERNAL APP	LISTED APP
`conversations.history` `conversations.replies`	**1 req/min, max 15 objects**	50+ req/min, 1,000 objects	Standard tiers
Other methods	Standard tiers	Standard tiers	Standard tiers

What this means for an agent

Reading the last 200 messages of one busy channel takes about 14 minutes. Until you are listed, design around events (subscribe to new messages as they arrive) instead of polling history.

Open conflict

Slack's original May 29, 2025 post says existing installs of unlisted apps are not affected. Slack's changelog index says existing installs are affected from March 3, 2026. Plan as if all installs are throttled. Conflict

09 Tokens

What an unattended agent must handle

SETTING	ACCESS TOKEN	REFRESH TOKEN	WHAT BREAKS
Rotation off (default)	Never expires	None	Only uninstall or admin removal revokes it
Rotation on	Expires every 12 hours	New one on every refresh; the old one is revoked	Losing the newest refresh token kills the connection (`invalid_grant`)

PKCE is a separate opt-in on the OAuth & Permissions page, required only for custom URI scheme redirects (for example `myapp://`). Whether rotation can be turned off after opting in was not checked.

10 Data use and compliance

Rules that shape agent design

- **No LLM training** on data from Slack APIs, for apps used outside the installing organization.
- **No bulk export** of messages and files without a separate agreement.
- **Keep only what you need.** Use, processing and retention must be the minimum the app needs to run.
- **No persistent copies or indexes** of other organizations' data via the Data Access and Real-time Search APIs. Brief caching only.

Design impact

"Sync the whole workspace into a vector database" is ruled out for a distributed app. Query live, cache briefly.

Slack API terms

11 Credential handoff

Can the secret reach Composio without anyone seeing it?

Level 1 · Fully automatic

An app can be created through Slack's manifest API, which returns the credentials to a backend tool that sends them straight to a Composio auth config. The model only sees "auth config created".

Slack appears to support this. Not yet verified.

Level 2 · Browser copy-paste

An agent clicks the console's copy button and pastes into Composio, never reading or screenshotting the value. Works, but one careless screenshot leaks it.

Level 3 · Human required

You reveal the secret yourself and paste it once. Today's default. In our test the secret was never opened by the agent.

Store secrets in Composio's auth config or a secrets manager. Never in a spreadsheet or a chat.

12 Common blockers

Symptom, cause, fix

SYMPTOM	CAUSE	FIX
`invalid_team_for_non_distributed_app`	Distribution not activated	Manage Distribution, then Activate Public Distribution
`redirect_uri` mismatch	URL differs from the registered one, or is not HTTPS	Copy the exact callback from your Composio auth config
History calls return 15 messages and get rate limited	Unlisted app throttle	Use events, or go through Marketplace review
`invalid_grant` on refresh	Rotation on, an old refresh token was reused	Store the newest refresh token every time
Agent missing new permissions	Scopes added but workspaces did not reinstall	Ask users to reconnect; check granted scopes
Customer cannot install in their company workspace	Their admin requires app approval	Give customers an admin-approval note Not checked

13 Evidence

How sure we are, and why

CLAIM	STATUS	BASIS
App created and installed in one step; settings at app.slack.com	Tested	Created "OAuth Readiness Test" on Oct 28, 2026
Distribution activates instantly with no review	Tested	Activated in our test; matched a secondary source
Owning workspace cannot be changed	Tested	Warning shown in the creation form
Deactivating distribution uninstalls everywhere	Tested	Warning shown after activation
Token rotation off by default; PKCE opt-in	Tested	Default manifest and OAuth settings page
1 req/min and 15 objects for unlisted apps	Official docs	Slack changelog, May 29, 2025
Whether existing installs are throttled	Conflict	Original post says no; changelog index says from March 3, 2026
Review: ≤ 10 business days + ≤ 10 weeks; 10 active workspaces	Official docs	Marketplace review guide; console shows the install counter
No LLM training, no bulk export, minimal retention	Official docs	Slack API Terms of Service
Manifest API returns credentials (level 1 handoff)	Not checked	To verify before relying on it
Admin app approval blocks customer installs	Not checked	From experience

Sources

- Slack: Rate limit changes for non-Marketplace apps (docs.slack.dev/changelog/2025/05/29)
- Slack: Marketplace review guide (docs.slack.dev/slack-marketplace/slack-marketplace-review-guide)
- Slack: API Terms of Service (slack.com/terms-of-service/api)
- Slack: Using token rotation (docs.slack.dev/authentication/using-token-rotation)
- Nango: invalid_team_for_non_distributed_app (nango.dev/blog)
- Composio: Managed vs custom auth (docs.composio.dev)
- Hands-on test log: attempts/slack.md in the project repository